



PHOTOGRAPH: Mexy Xavier

Spent thousands of rupees on the new PC and your child uses it only for games? How to ensure that learning happens along with the fun...

Kid-stuff?

Kid's tough!

You have high dreams for your child—software engineer, high-profile programmer in Microsoft or Oracle, inventor of a language, etc. Charged, you buy a PC and cram it with all kinds of software, tutorials and encyclopaedia. But your child shuns all your attempts and does not spend more than a few minutes at the computer everyday. How do you get him interested?

Don't force it!

Making your kids love PCs is a lot like getting them to read. Just make sure that you arouse their innate curiosity. The rest will happen soon. Operating systems have become so user friendly that kids can use them with just a little bit of guidance. The best kind of education is one in which kids learn while having fun. So, for a start, liven up things with games and help your child get comfortable about using the computer.

But that doesn't mean you allow your child to play a 'blood-gore' game such as *Quake*, if he does his tutorial homework first. Instead, get your child the right games for his age. Anyone who has ever played *Where in the World is Carmen Sandiego?* would vouch for the educational features in this highly interesting game. The game, with you as the detective, involves capturing the ace-thief Carmen Sandiego, but before that, you have to capture her henchmen. You travel through continents and countries, and the clues test your knowledge of history, geography and culture. *Carmen Sandiego* will get your

brat well-versed with the currency of Rwanda and the colours of the flag of Egypt.

Puzzles, crosswords and word games increase problem solving and comprehension skills. You can play *Scrabble* on the computer too, while a game such as *Tetris* will test their skill at understanding blocks and placing them together.

Multimedia magic

Kids love things in which they get to have their say. This is where interactive programs such as multimedia software step in. Multimedia programs involve children and are a good way to excite their interest in computers. There are many programs available that teach basics such as counting, maths, letters, spelling, etc, through interactive tools. Many of these are available as freeware or shareware. (For a list of some of the hottest software for kids under the age of 10, check out the box, 'Kid-die Software'.)

If you have some money to spare, choose a multimedia CD title suited to your child's age. Take care to select one that matches your child's aptitude. Let him draw and colour pictures, and learn basics such as the alphabet and counting while playing the game. This will lay the foundation.

Drawing for dummies

Children are attracted to big dolls. Apart from the size, there's a visual attraction. The same analogy can be transferred to PCs and you can start your child off on the drawing path. A simple tool such as MS Paint is enough →

The Resource
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Web sites and
game details,
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www.thinkdigit.com